

# The Door Is Unlocked

*She came to GLMZ with a soldering iron and a head full of code.*

Pixel

# The Bus

The Behemoth was watching the bus pull out.

Vera knew it wasn't watching, technically. Iowan Behemoths didn't have eyes the way people meant *eyes* — they had pressure plates and ambient sensors and the long indifferent attention of a thing built to tend cornfields. But the autonom had risen up on its forward struts when the bus engaged the magnetic feeder line, and its dish-array had tilted toward the east, and Vera's neighbor Mrs. Kowalski-Obeng would have called that *minding*, and Mrs. Kowalski-Obeng was usually right about things that didn't need to be right.

*It's not minding*, Vera thought. *It's minding the field*.

The field was minded. The bus pulled out anyway.

She had the window seat, third row, pressed against the glass because the glass was the coolest surface within reach and she had not slept in two nights and wanted something to put her cheek on that wasn't her own arm. Outside: rows. Corn at second-cycle yellow, soy at meridian green, the irrigation drip-lines glinting where the early sun caught them. The Behemoth shrank into a comma against the horizon. Then a period. Then nothing the eye could resolve from a moving bus.

She didn't cry. She had decided not to cry forty miles back, when the bus had turned onto the corridor and the last familiar silo had passed behind her, and a decision once made was a decision. *You can renegotiate after the next stop*, she told herself, which was what her mother used to say about hard things, and which had nothing to do with not crying and everything to do with continuing to function, and was therefore exactly the right thing.

In her lap: the canvas roll. Inside the canvas roll: her mother's tools.

Not all of them. The cardiac kit had stayed with the cousin who had a cardiac client. The sutures had stayed with the clinic at the township line, because the clinic at the township line still had patients and Vera, at seventeen, did not yet. What she had taken were the diagnostic instruments — the calibrators, the hand probes, the small bone-handled set with the brass fittings that her mother had used to scrape gunk off of contact pads since before Vera could remember. The set had a leather band that snapped closed with a satisfying *click* and it was the most expensive thing Vera owned and she was carrying it across what had been Missouri once, what was now mostly water, and would arrive in GLMZ before sundown with it still snapped shut against her thigh.

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Also in her lap: the boots, off her feet, because the boots did not fit yet. Black steel-toed, scuffed at the toe to a glint of underlayer, repaired at the sole twice already. They had been her mother's. Her mother had been five-eight. Vera was — five-foot-nothing, five-foot-and-an-attitude — and her feet had not yet decided what they were going to be. Walking in the boots was like walking in good shelter. You wore the shelter until you grew into it. *Eventually*, she thought, *the leather will know me*. She was prepared to wait.

The earbuds were in her ears, but only the left one worked. The right side had cracked at the connector somewhere around hour fourteen and she was going to fix it at her next stable seat, which was not this one. The left earbud was playing what she had loaded onto the chip before leaving — eight hours of music she had pulled off old town-network archives, badly compressed, full of clicks where the encoding had failed, and she had decided the clicks were percussion.

One of the songs was an old American song from before the Centennial. Acoustic guitar, woman singing, lyrics about a road. Vera couldn't remember whose road it had been. She remembered her mother humming the chorus once, in the small kitchen in the small house, while she had made coffee on a small stove. Vera, eleven, had been at the table doing arithmetic. Her mother had been at the stove. The smell of coffee and the hum and the morning light on the linoleum.

The song played. Vera looked at the cornfields.

*Hi, Mom*, she thought. *I'm leaving now. I know you know.*

The woman two seats ahead of her had been watching the toolkit.

Vera felt it the way you feel a slight thumb of pressure on the back of your neck when someone in a room has decided to attend to you. The woman was older — fifty, maybe, dark-skinned with a deeper undertone of red where the bus light caught her cheekbone, hair cut close to her skull and silvered at the temples. She had been reading something on a paper-thin reader and her eyes had drifted left, then sharpened, then rested on the canvas roll. Vera felt her mother's tools become visible.

She started to slide the roll behind her bag.

"Don't," the woman said. Quiet. Not mean. "I'm not going to take it."

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Vera stopped sliding.

"That's a field medic's roll," the woman said. "Pre-corp. Mid-century leather. The brass fittings on a Reisman set. I haven't seen one of those in fifteen years."

"It was my mother's."

The woman's face did the thing faces do when they have already understood the next sentence before the speaker has reached it. She did not say *I'm sorry*. Vera was grateful. She had decided, three months ago, that she was going to find people who didn't say it and stay near them.

"Where you headed," the woman said.

"Refugee processing at the East Pulse Hub. Then — I don't know. They give you a list."

"They give you a list," the woman agreed, with the small private smile of someone who had once been given a list. "Listen. The list is real but it isn't the whole map. You go to the East Hub, you process, you take the bunk for the night because the bunk is free and you need sleep more than you need pride. In the morning you don't take the list housing. You take the West Town transit. You get off at Ashland and Chicago. You walk to the corner building with the cream brick, the rounded face, the two addresses on the front."

"Two addresses?"

"Two addresses. Either is real. Neither is complete. The landlord likes that. He'll like you because you have those tools and you know what they do, and because you're scared in a way that he'll recognize as serviceable. He doesn't take credits the first month. He takes a favor he'll name later, and you'll do it, and the favor will be reasonable. After that it's two-fifty Quanta, paid in person, paid late if you have to but paid."

Vera was writing it down. She wrote on the inside of her left forearm with a thin marker because notebooks attracted attention and forearms didn't. *Ashland. Chicago. Cream brick. Rounded.*

"What's the building called."

"It's not called anything. The people who live there call it The Pivot."

## The Bus

"The Pivot."

"You're going to need a name to give the landlord," the woman said, "that isn't on your refugee paperwork. I'd suggest something short. Something that sounds like a tool, because you carry tools, and people remember names that match the bag they came in."

Vera looked at her toolkit. She looked at the cornfields, going.

"Pixel," she said. It came out without thinking, the way a name does when it's been waiting.

"Pixel." The woman tried it. "Yes. That'll work."

She reached into her own bag. Vera tensed — not in fear, in the small electric way you tense when a stranger reaches for something on your behalf. The woman pulled out a small flat package, thin foil, sealed.

"Diagnostic clip," the woman said. "Sterile. Civilian-grade but the brand is good. You won't have time to sterilize anything when you start working again, and you will start working again. Take it."

"I don't have anything to —"

"You don't owe me anything. I owed someone else this when I was your age. They didn't take payment either." She put the foil packet on Vera's tray. "My name is Hoa. If you need a name for someone who told you about The Pivot, it isn't mine. Use *Auntie*. The landlord will know who you mean."

Vera looked at the foil packet on the tray. It caught the bus light. It looked, in that light, exactly like the kind of thing her mother used to slip into her pocket on rounds — a small clean instrument waiting for the moment it would be needed.

She wrote it down. *Auntie Hoa*.

Then she crossed it out, because Hoa had said not to use her name, and wrote *Auntie* instead, and then she put the marker away and put the packet in the canvas roll and snapped the roll closed with the satisfying *click*.

The bus rolled east.

The left earbud was still playing. The song had moved on to something else, something Vera

# The Bus

didn't recognize but liked anyway, a thing with a fast slipping bassline that the encoding clicks made into percussion.

She pressed her cheek against the cool window. She watched the world that was no longer hers slide past. She thought, with the small clear surprise that would later become a habit:

*I am not actually doing this badly.*

The Behemoth was long gone behind her, minding its field. The boots were heavy in her lap. The tools were quiet. The packet was new.

She was, she realized, a person with three things now. A name that fit the bag. A list, and the route around the list. And one packet of clean foil from a stranger who hadn't asked for thanks.

*Pixel*, she practiced, in the privacy of her own head.

It sounded like something.

It sounded like *her*.

## Two Addresses

The building was exactly the way the woman on the bus had said it would be. Cream brick, rounded at the corner, two real addresses on the doorframe. Pixel — she was practicing the name, even in her head; *Pixel, Pixel* — stood across the intersection for a full minute before she crossed.

Not from fear. From wanting to remember.

She had been raised by a person who taught her that the moment before you walked into a place was a moment that belonged to you, and you could spend it however you wanted. *Spend it well*, her mother used to say, and what she meant was *don't rush past the door, the door is where you decide to be different*.

Pixel decided, on the corner of Ashland and Chicago, to become someone who lived in a building with two addresses. It was a small decision and it was instant and it stuck.

She crossed.

The Chicago Avenue door was the one that opened. The Ashland door was decorative — older, varnished, locked with a key she didn't have and might never have. The Chicago door had a standard cylinder lock and a button that connected to nothing visible and a hand-lettered card slipped behind a brass plate that read MR. ADAMU 2D, FOR INQUIRIES.

She knocked on the doorframe rather than pressing the button.

A voice from the second-floor window: "Up here."

Mr. Adamu was sixty, pear-shaped, with the careful tired eyes of someone who had outlived three different landlord eras and adjusted each time. He came down in slippers. He looked at her toolkit before he looked at her face. He said, "Auntie sent you," without ascertainment, and Pixel said, "Yes," and Mr. Adamu said, "Come up. Don't take the boots off, I don't care, the floor doesn't care, I will tell you who cares about the floor in a minute."

The unit was 2E. Across the hall from a closed door marked 2F that smelled, faintly, of clean motor oil and a kind of soap she didn't recognize.

"That's Mr. Corbin-Vister," Mr. Adamu said, when he saw her notice the door. "He cares about the floor. Outside his unit. Inside his unit he doesn't care. Inside *yours* you can do whatever the building structurally permits, which is a very generous range."

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The unit had: two windows, one over Chicago and one over the alley. A hot plate. A radiator from 2040 that he made her listen to before he agreed to the lease. A bathroom with a tub. A closet. A wall socket that he warned her not to overload but that she immediately knew she would overload, because *of course she would*, because she knew what she was going to do with the unit and the unit's wall socket did not yet know.

"Two-fifty Quanta a month," Mr. Adamu said. "You don't have it."

"Not yet."

"First month is a favor. You'll do something for me. I'll name it later. It will be reasonable."

"What's the favor going to be."

"I don't know yet," Mr. Adamu said, and the careful tired eyes glinted with something that was not quite humor and not quite warning. "That's the point. The favor is the thing I don't yet know I'll need. You'll be here when I need it."

"I'll be here."

"That's the contract."

She slept on the floor that night because she did not yet have a bed. The radiator from 2040 ran softly, the way a kettle that hasn't quite boiled runs softly, a working presence. Through the wall she could hear the building's electrical hum and somewhere — she did not know where, she would never quite locate it — a music she did not recognize, low, late, considered. She made a small inventory before sleep.

*One bag. One toolkit. The boots. The packet from Auntie. A unit. A landlord. A favor I owe and don't yet know.*

She slept. She did not dream of the cornfields. She dreamed of nothing she could remember, which she took, in the morning, as a kindness.

— — —

The workbench arrived on day three.

It was not bought. It was *constructed*, which was a different verb. She walked the alley

## Two Addresses

behind the Pivot with the eyes of a person who had been pricing components since age nine and had a clear ranking system for materials her mother had taught her — *steel beats wood beats plastic*, her mother had said, *unless the plastic is the right plastic, in which case the plastic wins, but you will know*. On day three Pixel found a 1.6-meter slab of laminated steel bedrock, a stress fracture across one corner, in a contractor's discard pile behind a building that was being eaten by another building. She paid for it in attention — she stood next to the man dismantling the building until he noticed her, and she said *can I take that*, and the man, who had a son her age somewhere east, looked at the slab and looked at her and said *you carry that yourself, you can have it*.

She carried it herself. It took an hour. The freight elevator in The Pivot had been broken since 2197 and would remain broken until it killed someone, which in Mr. Adamu's calculation was a different problem. She brought the slab up the back stairs in three pieces — she had brought a saw, *of course* she had brought a saw — and reassembled it on the floor of Unit 2E with bolts and a steel band, and at hour four she had a workbench.

She named it *Maeve*. She did not know why. It just was Maeve.

"Hello, Maeve," she said, and the workbench did not say anything back, but Maeve was a thing that existed now, a thing she had made.

She stood in the unit, alone, with Maeve.

She thought, with the small clear surprise that was becoming her particular form of grace: *I am not, actually, doing this badly*.

— — —

The first patient was Mrs. Eldering on the first floor.

Mrs. Eldering was eighty, Czech-Trinidadian, retired-from-something-she-wouldn't-discuss, and her cardiac assist had been chirping on the wrong beat for four days and her grandson didn't know what to do and her grandson worked at the noodle shop on the next block where Mr. Adamu ate twice a week, and the chain of mention from the noodle shop to Mr. Adamu to Mrs. Eldering to *the new girl in 2E with the good toolkit* took seventeen minutes.

Pixel knocked on the door of 1A.

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"It's me," she said, even though Mrs. Eldering had no idea who *me* was. "It's Pixel. Mr. Adamu sent me."

Mrs. Eldering opened the door. Mrs. Eldering looked at her with the assessing eye of a woman who had watched the GLMZ swallow specialists and unlicensed pretenders in equal proportion for sixty years.

"You're little," Mrs. Eldering said.

"I'm aware."

"Are you good."

"My mother was good. She taught me. So either yes or working on it."

Mrs. Eldering let her in.

The cardiac assist was a Bauer-Naidu unit, fifteen years out of warranty, the kind of thing licensed cyberdocs would tell you needed to be replaced. It did not need to be replaced. It needed to be cleaned and recalibrated and the contact at the third lead pad needed three minutes of patient attention with one of the brass-handled probes from the canvas roll. Pixel did the work in twenty-eight minutes. She narrated quietly while she worked because she had decided early — fourteen, kitchen table, watching her mother — that silence over someone's nervous system was a kind of disrespect. The patient deserved a voice. The voice did not need to be interesting. It needed to be *there*.

"There's a degraded contact on the third lead. Just gunk. I'm cleaning it. Hold still. I know — I know it tickles, that's the gel. The chirp is going to stop in about a minute. There. Hear it? That's the right interval. That's what you should have been hearing."

Mrs. Eldering listened.

Mrs. Eldering started to cry, the dry brief crying of a person who had stopped trusting the small mercies and had to relearn one in the moment.

"I haven't slept," Mrs. Eldering said. "In four days. The wrong rhythm gets in your sleep."

"You'll sleep tonight."

Mrs. Eldering paid her thirty Quanta and a jar of pickled cucumbers and a slip of paper that

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*said if anyone gives you trouble in this building tell them you are with me.*

Pixel walked back up the stairs to Unit 2E.

She set the thirty Quanta on Maeve. She set the cucumbers on Maeve. She unfolded the slip of paper and looked at Mrs. Eldering's signature — a *clean* signature, the practiced cursive of someone who had owned things — and put the paper in the canvas roll, snapped the roll closed.

She sat on the floor next to Maeve.

She thought, very carefully:

*I have a workbench. I have a patient who lived. I have thirty Quanta and a jar of cucumbers and a sentence I can carry into a fight if I need to.*

*I am here.*

*This is the unit. This is the floor. This is the wall.*

*This is the start of it.*

She turned the music on.

Low at first. Then, after a minute, *louder*, because she had decided that a person who had survived the bus and the cornfield and the corner of Ashland and Chicago, and had arrived alive in a unit with a workbench named Maeve, deserved music she could feel in her teeth.

The radiator from 2040 ran softly underneath. The wall socket did not yet know what was coming.

In 2F, across the hall, Mr. Corbin-Vister — whoever he was — paused, briefly, behind his door. Pixel did not know about the pause.

She was busy. She was home.

## 2F

Pixel had been counting.

Not deliberately. The counting was a side-effect of *living in a building*, which was something she had not done before — her childhood house had been a freestanding box on a quarter-acre, and the clinic she had slept in for six months between her mother and the bus had been a converted barn — and a building was a thing where other people's rhythms touched yours, and rhythms were a thing she could not help but notice. The man in 2F had a footfall that was eleven beats from his door to the top of the stairs, which was two beats slower than her own, which meant he was not avoiding the stairs the way someone hurt avoids them but he was *measuring* them, which was something else.

He came home at 0247 most nights. He left at 1100 most mornings. There was a Tuesday where he didn't come home at all, and there was a Thursday after that where he came home at 0530 and stood in the hallway for ninety seconds before unlocking his door, and Pixel, in her unit, had been awake at her workbench — Maeve was always awake — and had heard the ninety seconds and had wanted to open her own door and ask if he was alright.

She had not opened her door. She had decided early, on something she could not articulate, that there were certain forms of attention a person did not extend without invitation. She knew the rule. She enforced it on herself.

The first conversation happened on day twenty-three.

It happened because of a mutual problem with takeout.

The stairwell of The Pivot had a step at the second-floor landing where the wall met the banister at a tight angle and a person carrying a wide bag had to either turn sideways or lift the bag overhead. Pixel had been carrying noodles up the stairs from the place on the next block — two cartons in a paper bag, the bag damp at the bottom because the noodle place was generous with broth — and she had reached the angle and was negotiating the lift-overhead maneuver, which she was good at, when the man from 2F came down the stairs and reached the same angle from above.

They looked at each other.

Pixel had seen him in the hallway eleven times. He had seen her, she suspected, the same number. Neither of them had said anything until now.

## 2F

He was tall. Not unusually so — she had pegged him at six foot, which she would later learn was correct — but he had the verticality of a person who had nothing left over to spend on width. The face was narrow, the eyes were dark, the cheekbones were the kind of sharp that suggests a chemistry problem, the hardware-metabolism-too-fast problem she had only read about and would later get to know in calibration logs. There was a katana — a real one, *that's a real katana*, she thought, *with a corundum strop guard* — across his back, in a low rig that she registered the engineering of before she registered the social implication.

He registered her toolkit. She had it slung over her shoulder because she had been at Mr. Patel's repairing a kitchen unit and had not put it down. He registered the kit, he registered the boots, he registered her hair — *which is, fair, hard to miss*, she thought — and then his eyes did the thing where they cataloged her and put her in the *not currently a threat, possibly relevant later* drawer, and she watched him do it.

"Sorry," he said.

It was the first word she had ever heard him speak. His voice was lower than she had expected and had the particular flatness of someone who had decided, somewhere along the way, that vocal performance was a tax he wasn't paying.

"For what," she said, because *sorry* was a noise people made when they wanted you to do something for them, like step aside, and she wanted to know which.

He paused.

He had not, she realized, expected to be asked.

"For not — " he started, and stopped, and recalibrated. "For taking up the angle."

"You're not taking it up. You're standing at it. There's a difference."

His eyes did something. Not a smile. Not even close to a smile. But the *thinking* moved across his face the way water moves across a flat stone — visible, and a little colder than expected, and gone.

"Go ahead," he said.

"You go ahead. I'm carrying soup. You're going down. Gravity is on your side. You've earned the angle."

## 2F

He stepped past her at the angle. He did it without making contact with her bag, which a less careful person would have done; he tilted exactly the right number of degrees and was past, and the only point of contact was the air, and the air she had felt move was — *trained*, she thought. *That movement was trained.*

At the bottom of his step he paused. He turned half-around without turning all the way, the way a person checks something they have already decided about.

"What's your name," he said.

"Pixel."

"Pixel."

"And you're 2F. I know the unit. I don't know the man."

"Kyle."

"Just Kyle."

"Just Kyle."

"Welcome to the second floor, Kyle. We have a stairwell with a tight angle. We work around it."

He nodded. Once.

He went down the stairs.

She took her noodles up to Unit 2E and put them on Maeve and sat on the floor and ate one carton standing because she had not realized until the noodles were in front of her how hungry she had been, and while she ate she did the thing she did when she had encountered a new piece of equipment for the first time — she ran the inventory.

*Six foot. Lean past lean. Hardware metabolism — visible. Trained movement, at least in the close-quarters bracket. Real katana, mounted with a corundum strop, which is not a thing you put on a katana you're not going to use. Voice flat by choice. Eyes that catalog. Polite — but the politeness is reflexive, not warm. Not currently a threat. Possibly relevant later. Lives across the hall.*

## 2F

*Likes me.*

She paused, mid-noodle, on the last line.

It was not vanity. She had no investment in being liked by him; she had not yet had time to develop one. The *likes me* was a diagnostic readout, the same flat factual register she would have used on a contact pad. The man at the angle had registered her *as a person*, and had spoken to her, and had asked her name, and had repeated her name, and had paused before going down the stairs to ask the question he wanted to ask, which was *who are you and are you a problem*, and the way he had asked it had not been hostile. It had been the deliberate caution of a person who had decided you might be a thing he wanted to know about.

He was not, she realized, going to say more for a while. That was fine.

She closed the carton.

She set it next to the thirty Quanta and the jar of Mrs. Eldering's pickled cucumbers and the slip of paper, all of which had become a small ritual altar on the corner of Maeve.

She added a mental note. She did not write it on her arm; she had been writing on her arm less now, because the unit had a wall and the wall had a square of bare brick that her marker took, and the wall was building a private notebook of things she would not forget.

On the wall she wrote: *2F. Kyle. Six foot. Cataloging eyes. Seven sentences. He likes me.*

She stepped back.

She added one more line under it, because the wall deserved the truth and Maeve was watching:

*Might be a project.*

She turned the music up to mid-volume, which was loud enough to be heard in 2F if 2F was paying attention, which she now believed 2F was, and went back to work on the kitchen unit.

The radiator from 2040 ran softly underneath, supportive, neutral, present.

The building rearranged itself, very slightly, around the new fact of two doors that had now spoken.

## Bourbon and Bullet Holes

It was 0247.

It was Wednesday, which Pixel knew because she had been three weeks past the previous Wednesday — three weeks past the noodle bag, three weeks past the angle in the stairwell, three weeks past *Kyle, six foot, seven sentences*. They had spoken at the angle four more times since. None of the conversations had gone past nine sentences. None of them had gone backwards either.

She was at Maeve, which is to say she was *home*, and the wall was singing softly because she had the music at three-quarter volume and the radiator at the same level it always ran, and she was reflowing a connector on a 4-line bus board that belonged to a man on the third floor who needed it back by morning. Her shit-kicker boots were off, on the mat by the door. Her enormous sweater — the *real* one, the heathered grey, the one she had decided two months ago was the only sweater that mattered — was over her hands. The right wrist gyrostabilizer was three months old, still healing, and made a tiny *purr* under fine work that nobody else could hear.

She heard the footfall on the stairs.

It was 2F's footfall — the eleven-beat one — but it was *wrong*. Off-tempo. The third step had been doubled. The fifth step had skipped. The seventh step had landed too hard. Pixel's hands stopped moving on the bus board and her head turned a quarter-inch toward the door without her telling it to.

*Drunk*, she thought, and then she thought, *no*, and the *no* arrived with a small clean panic she had not asked for.

She set the iron down.

She was at the door before she had fully decided to be at the door. She opened it.

Kyle was at the top of the stairs. He had stopped. He was using the wall. The wall was holding him up by exactly the surface of his right shoulder and a smear of his right palm.

The wall, Pixel registered, was darker than wall.

*Not bourbon.*

"Hi," she said. Light. Not a question. Light because alarm in this moment would have been

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an *insult* — this man did not need her surprise; he needed her hands.

"Sorry," Kyle said. His voice had the careful carved precision of a person who had practiced his words on the way up the stairs. "Wrong floor."

"This is your floor."

"Right."

"Come here."

He didn't move.

She walked the four steps to him. She did not touch him. She got under his right arm — the one that was not currently a wall-prop — and let him decide whether to lean. He leaned. She felt his weight settle, and the weight told her three things in one second: *upper torso, left side, wet.*

"Two-E," she said. "Maeve has good light. Come on."

"I'll bleed on it."

"Maeve's bled on before. Maeve forgives."

She got him into the unit. She got him onto Maeve, which was the right surface — the workbench had a clean steel laminate that she could wipe in one stroke, and a lip around the edge that caught fluids before fluids became a problem on the floor, and Pixel had not, when she'd named the workbench Maeve, anticipated this exact use case, but Maeve, like all good tools, was what you needed her to be when you needed her.

She killed the music with one hand.

She did not narrate yet. She would narrate; she always narrated when working. But the first sixty seconds of any field assessment was for the body, not for the mouth. She got the coat off — *one round, left lat, low*, she logged silently; *exit, yes, exit, also low, also clean* — and the shirt up. The bleed had slowed because of the cold and the angle and the meat that had stopped most of the round on the way through. She would have called it lucky if she had been the kind of medic who used that word. She was not.

"Hold still," she said, finally, out loud, when she had the surgical light on and the field of

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work clean. "I said hold still. I know you don't need me to say it. The narrating is for me."

"Okay."

"Tell me what hit you."

"Jacketed nine. Civilian."

"Through?"

"Through. Vest caught most of it. The lat got the rest."

"Not a vital. Decent angle. You got *lucky*, Kyle. Don't argue with me."

"I wasn't going to."

She worked.

She pulled the round's path open with two clamps and a finger and got the fragment that had stopped half-in — *jacketed, deformed, but whole, no sloughing* — and dropped it onto the steel of Maeve, and Maeve made a small flat *plink*, which was the right sound, the *good news* sound. She irrigated. She closed. She used the ChromaSeal because she had three left and this was a chromaseal injury, and Kyle did not flinch at the sting, which most people did, which told her something about Kyle she had already half-known and now formally filed.

The bullet hole was forty-five minutes.

The other thing took longer.

She found it because she was running her diagnostic clip — *Auntie's clip*, she still thought of it as Auntie's clip, three years later, the foil packet long since returned to the canvas roll with a small handwritten label inside — over the base of his skull as a precaution. She did this with everyone post-trauma. She was not looking for anything in particular. She had decided, at fifteen, that you ran the clip every time, because the time you didn't run it was the time you missed something.

The clip beeped. Then it beeped *wrong*.

*Wrong* in the diagnostic sense; not loud, not alarming, just — a tone she had not expected,

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in a frequency that meant *recheck this*.

She rechecked. She rechecked again.

The lateral array — the cluster of contact pads that sat behind his right ear, that handled the cross-talk between his NeoCortex implant and his autonomic baseline, that was responsible for *the boundary between his own signal and the bleed of everything else* — had three nodes glowing in thermal stress.

Not acute. Not red. Yellow, the steady patient yellow of *this has been failing for days and you have been ignoring it*.

"Kyle," she said. Quiet. Even. She did not stop scanning.

"Yeah."

"Your lateral array is running hot."

A silence.

She waited it out.

"How long," she said, "have you known about this."

The silence got longer. She watched the back of his neck, which was the only part of his face she could see right now. She watched the small muscle at the base of his jaw go *still*, which was not the same as relaxed.

"Six days."

"Six days."

"Maybe seven."

"Were you going to tell me."

"It's calibrating itself."

"Kyle. *No*. It is *not*." She set the clip down, because the clip was not the conversation now; the conversation was. She came around to the side of the bench so he could see her face, because she had decided that this part required eye contact. "Lateral arrays do not calibrate

## Bourbon and Bullet Holes

themselves out of a thermal stress profile. They calibrate themselves *into* one. If your delta-sync drops past eight percent variance — and it is at six right now, Kyle, you are *two points* from the edge — you start to lose the boundary between your own signal and the bleed. You start to confuse what is yours and what is *not yours*. The thing you don't like in your own head gets louder. The voice that says — the voice that —" She stopped. "You know what voice I mean."

He looked at her.

For exactly two seconds, the cataloging went away. There was something else underneath the cataloging, and then the cataloging came back.

"I know," he said.

"Six days, Kyle."

"I know."

"I am going to fix it. Right now. Lie back down."

He lay back down.

She ran a parallel jumper to bypass the failing nodes. She isolated the worst of the three. She pulled the contact pad — bone-handled probe, brass-fitted, *her mother's* probe, the one with the slight burr on the rim that her mother had worn smooth with her thumb over twenty years — and lifted the pad out and saw, immediately, the problem: a microfracture across the conductive trace, the kind you got from the unit running hot for six days and then cooling down too fast and then running hot again. The *sloppy* fracture. The fracture you got from a person not respecting their own equipment.

She fixed it with a piece of solder the size of a grain of rice and a drop of conductive paste from a tube she kept on Maeve in a little stand she had named *Reliquary*. She seated the pad back. She closed the array. She let the clip recheck.

The tone was *right*.

She sat back. She put the brass-handled probe down. She let her hands stop.

"Done," she said.

## Bourbon and Bullet Holes

"What was it."

"Microfracture in the third lateral. Six days of you ignoring it. A drop of paste. Two minutes."

"It's been —"

"Loud. I know."

A beat.

A second beat, longer than the first.

"Pixel," Kyle said. *Pixel*. Not *Vera*. Not *Hey*. Not *the girl across the hall*. It was the first time he had said her name with the specific flatness he reserved for things he had decided to commit to memory.

"Yeah."

"Thanks."

It was the first time he had said *thanks*.

She heard it. She filed it. She did not, by the smallest available muscle, react.

"It's six hundred Quanta if I bill you," she said, instead. "It's two cucumbers and a sentence I can use in a fight if I don't."

"Cucumbers," he said.

"It's a system."

"Two cucumbers."

"That's the going rate. Don't argue with me about your own bill."

He was quiet a long time. He was looking at the ceiling. The ceiling was not interesting; it was the ceiling of Unit 2E, which had a hairline crack in the plaster that had been there since 2147 and would be there in 2300.

"I'll bring two cucumbers," he said.

## Bourbon and Bullet Holes

"Tomorrow's fine."

He sat up slowly. The bullet hole hurt; she watched the muscle at his jaw register the exact frequency of pain and decide not to spend it. He pulled his shirt back together, and it was a wreck, and he handled it with the small dignity of a person who had decided the shirt could be a wreck and his manner could not.

At the door, with the night outside it, he paused.

"Pixel," he said.

"Yeah."

"Don't tell anyone you fixed the array."

"I haven't told anyone anything since 2217."

He nodded. Once.

He crossed the hall to 2F. He went in. The door closed.

She stood for a minute with her hand on her own doorframe.

She went back inside. She washed Maeve. She put the brass-handled probe back in the canvas roll. She added a small clean note to the brick wall, in the marker, under all the other notes:

*2F. Lateral array, third node. Fixed. He said it right.*

She stood back from the wall. She did not, at first, feel anything in particular. The feeling came later, the way it always did with her — slow, on a delay, arriving when she was about to fall asleep — and when it came it was not the feeling she had expected.

She had expected joy. She had expected the small bright satisfaction of a thing fixed.

What she got was the quiet sad warm thing that you got when you understood, all at once, that a person you had been politely curious about had been *quietly hurting* across the hall from you for six days and had not asked, and that he was the kind of person who would never ask, and that the asking — the *not* asking — was a wound of its own, and you were now *responsible* for it, in a small private way that did not require his permission.

## Bourbon and Bullet Holes

She lay on the floor next to Maeve. The radiator ran softly. The wall, she could see in the half-light, was filling up.

*Oh*, she thought.

*Oh, this is what this is.*

She did not name it. Naming it would have been overstepping. She let it be the unnamed thing it was.

In the morning, on her doormat, there were two cucumbers in a paper bag and a folded slip of paper. The paper said, in narrow careful handwriting she would later learn was Kyle's:

*The going rate. Plus a sentence: I owe you, and the building knows it.*

She added the slip to the canvas roll.

She added one more line to the wall, a small one, near the bottom, where she would see it every morning:

*The door is unlocked.*

She meant her own.

She meant it on purpose.

## The Door Is Unlocked

The roof of The Pivot was not, technically, accessible.

The building had been built in an era when access to a roof was a thing the city assumed people would not want, and the access hatch above the second-floor stairwell had been welded shut sometime around 2160 by a maintenance contractor who had since died and been buried by his nephew. The hatch had been re-opened, at some point, by a tenant whose name nobody now remembered, with a torch and a steady hand and a willingness to argue with three landlords across forty years that *no, you cannot reseal the hatch, the hatch is precedent now, the hatch is grandfathered*.

Mr. Adamu had inherited the argument. Mr. Adamu had also inherited his predecessor's quiet pragmatism about which fights to lose. The hatch was open. The roof was a thing.

Pixel went up there on Sundays.

It was Sunday. It was October. The light over GLMZ in October had a particular quality — the ferrocement wave to the west caught the late sun and threw it back up the lake corridor as a wide low coral that touched everything south-facing on the second story, including the roof of The Pivot, and turned the building's pigeons briefly into the most flattered pigeons in the western world.

She was on her bench, which she had hauled up four months ago across two trips. She had a soldering iron in one hand. She had a coffee in the other. She had an enormous sweater that was *not* the heathered grey, because the heathered grey was sacred and reserved for Maeve; this was the burgundy one, the *secondary* sweater, the one she wore when she wanted to feel like the burgundy version of herself. The boots were on. They had finally fit, eight months ago, and the leather had welcomed her in the particular way leather did when it agreed to be yours, and she did not, anymore, take them off in the unit unless the floor specifically required it.

The music was in her ears, both ears, because she had finally fixed the right earbud — *years* ago, she had fixed it, a hundred and seven Sundays ago, in fact — and the song that was playing was the old American song from before the Centennial, the one with the road, the one her mother had hummed at the stove. She had it on a loop because she was working with one hand and the loop did not require new attention. It was a song for the inside of a habit.

## The Door Is Unlocked

Somewhere below her, in 2F, Kyle was — she knew, because she had been doing the listening she did without trying for years — *not* home. He had been gone since Friday. He would come back tonight or tomorrow. He would come back hurt or tired or both. She would know within ninety seconds of his footfall on the stairs. She would offer; he would accept or not; either was fine.

She had figured it out about four months in.

She had not, at the time, set out to figure it out. The figuring-out had arrived the way conclusions arrived to her — slowly, while her hands were doing something else. She had been on Maeve, recalibrating his lateral array for the seventh time, and Kyle had said something — she could not now remember what; the *what* had not been the point — and she had glanced up at his face, and the face had done the thing it did, which was *not* the cataloging, was something else, and she had thought, with the small clear startle that was her only mode of intuition:

*Oh. He likes me. He likes me back.*

And then, two seconds behind it, the harder thought:

*And he is keeping the distance on purpose.*

She had finished the calibration. She had said nothing. She had walked Kyle to the door. She had closed her own door behind him. She had stood in her unit with the music down and run, in her head, the inventory of every small thing about him she had ever filed, and had matched each small thing to the new framework, and the framework had held — the way a *good* framework held, where the data did not have to be coerced; the data simply *fit*.

Kyle did not allow people close to him because *people close to him were used*. It was not a guess. It was the entire shape of his life. The corundum strop. The flat voice. The cataloging eyes. The eleven-beat footfall measured because measuring was what you did when you had decided, somewhere along the way, that nobody could afford to know your tells. He had not invented the rule that closeness was weakness; he had *paid* for the rule. The price had been someone, or several someones, who had not made it.

He had decided, a long time before her, that he would not make her one of the someones.

She had stood in the unit and let the framework settle.

## The Door Is Unlocked

She had not, the surprise of her own life, felt rejected.

She had felt — *seen*, she thought, and the *seen* was not from him; the *seen* was from herself; she had finally seen the shape of what she had walked into, and the shape was not a smaller life than she'd thought, and it was not a larger one, it was *exactly the size* of the life she had — and she had thought, plainly: *I can live in this. This is a life. He is across the hall. I am here. We will both still be here on Tuesday.*

She had named the framework on the brick wall. Small. Bottom corner. Where she could see it every morning.

*The asymmetry holds. The asymmetry is not the wound.*

Under it, two days later, she had added: *The wound is mine. The boots are mine. The unit is mine. He is across the hall, and he is across the hall on purpose. He will be there tomorrow. So will I.*

Nobody else had ever read the wall. The wall was for her.

The roof was, currently, for her too.

She took a sip of the coffee. The coffee was bad in the specific way only coffee made by yourself in your own unit at 0600 on a Sunday in October could be bad — meaning, in some private reading, *perfect*. She set the mug down on the bench. She picked the iron back up. She had a board to finish for a man on the third floor who needed it back by morning. The third-floor man's name was Berto. Berto had a daughter who was thirteen and was learning, slowly, badly, with much delight, how to play a cracked plastic flute that Pixel had repaired twice. The flute would need a third repair within a year. Pixel would do the third repair. The flute did not yet know.

She worked. The light moved.

The ferrocement wave to the west caught the sun at the exact angle that meant the day was about to change registers — coral becoming gold, gold becoming the long flat afternoon — and the city under it was a thing she had once arrived in at seventeen with a bag of tools and a pair of boots that didn't fit, and which, she registered, six years and change later, had not killed her, had not even *meaningfully* hurt her, had instead given her —

## The Door Is Unlocked

A list. *I have a list*, she thought, without writing it down, because the wall already had it.

*A unit. A workbench named Maeve. A song from before the Centennial. The boots. The brass-handled probe. The diagnostic clip from a stranger named Auntie. A jar of pickled cucumbers, replenished every six weeks by Mrs. Eldering, who was now ninety-one and considered Pixel her granddaughter without telling her so. A flute belonging to a thirteen-year-old. A landlord whose favor was now my responsibility to know without being told. A man across the hall.*

*A door. Unlocked.*

She smiled. Just a little. Just for herself.

A pigeon — flattered, gilded — landed on the parapet four feet from her bench. The pigeon was magnificent. The pigeon had a small piece of plastic in its beak that it was going to weave into its nest, because GLMZ pigeons did not understand that some things were not nest material and had decided, at some point in their species' tenure here, that they did not have to.

*Defiance*, Pixel thought, watching the pigeon. *That is what defiance looks like. It looks like an idiot bird with the wrong material.*

She finished the solder. She set the iron in the stand. She picked up her coffee. She watched the light.

Downstairs, in 2F, the unit was empty. The unit would not be empty by tomorrow. Pixel would know within ninety seconds.

In 2E, Maeve was waiting. Maeve always waited. Maeve was the patient member of the household.

The wall, Pixel thought, would have something new to add tonight. It always did.

She drank the coffee. The coffee was bad. The roof was hers. The city was hers in the specific way the city *let* a person have it, which was not really at all, but in the moment, was *enough*.

She was, she registered, not doing this badly.

She was, in fact, doing it on purpose.

## CHAPTER 5

# The Door Is Unlocked

She sat with the iron and the coffee and the gilded pigeon and the song from before the Centennial in both ears, and watched October light hit a city that had tried to be unkind to her, and had failed.